

it snakes along its route. The area by the Tigris is much different than the surrounding areas of the Euphrates. The houses that line the Tigris are large complexes and reek of affluence. There are little cafes that line the road and overlook the river. They have plastic deck furniture and little umbrellas to shield their patrons from the sun. Of course, in the aftermath of the war, the residents of the city have more to worry about than fetching a Kebab at the local riverside deli, so the cafes were empty, but there none the less. The street along the river was lined with large trees and some of the side roads could have come right out of a movie set in Italy. It is a really nice part of town. This is a drastic contrast to the Euphrates which is a fairly narrow river situated outside of the city limits. It is surrounded by peasants, and goat herders are a much more normal site than a café.

The time at Brigade was a nice get-away if uneventful. I met with the Brigade Chemical Officer and submitted my USR Report for this month. Sustained operations and a limited supply line has caused 2-70 to drop from readiness level one to level two. Its no big deal really. Meanwhile I enjoyed the new scenery, the air conditioning of the building, and the cold soda. I tried to use the Internet access there, but the computer just would not connect. I don't think this is unusual since we are working on a makeshift system. Oh well, no email. I am now forced back to writing a letter and hoping that it gets delivered.

While at Brigade, unbeknownst to me, an entirely new opportunity was developing back at the 2-70 AR TOC. I have been somewhat upset about my lot in life since finding out that Sproesser was getting cut loose to enjoy a new life at an Armor Company. I wanted so desperately to be involved in some missions and to earn my keep in this environment. I wanted to reach out beyond the confines of my TOC, and do some "real work." Well, fortune may have come my way today. When I arrived back at the TOC, it was—of course—time for me to come back on shift again. I reported for duty as I always do and began to collect sitreps and track the locations of our units when I answered our MSRT Phone. It was some Major calling from Brigade and he wanted to know how we planned to recover one of Charlie Companies tanks that was hit with DU rounds while on a mission up north near Tikrit. Well, DU rung a bell immediately. It is depleted uranium, a new munition used in tank rounds and is mildly radioactive. It does not pose a risk if handled correctly and was something I studied back at Leonard Wood. I asked the Colonel this evening if I could go on the mission since I have some expertise in the area. To my surprise he responded favorably and suggested that I mention to the XO that I am willing to lead the recovery mission. I don't yet know if I will get the call, but I will keep my fingers crossed. Tikrit is a ways away and the mission pertains to my training. Hopefully I will finally get a chance to do what I am trained to do.

OK, back to real life. This evening has been fairly hectic. Yesterday's calm, and almost silent night, has been replaced by a slew of uprisings and criminal events. Earlier one of our scout sections was dispatched to retrieve an EPW found with an AK-47 in a stolen truck. The truck was filled with stolen sugar. How much better can this get. Well, when the scouts where on their way to the criminal cage to detain this person, they passed through a marketplace where an angry mob had gathered. The mob began pelting the HMMWVs with rocks. The scouts could not fire back and fled the scene, still delivering

our prisoner to custody. The Brigade commander decided against sending tanks into the marketplace tonight, opting rather to address the situation with local leaders in the morning.

A few hours later Bounty called in reporting that their section guarding the Chlorine Plant in our area came under direct fire. The tankers were engaged by two gunmen firing AKs. They returned fire and managed to disperse the assailants. A group of civilian rubber-neckers quickly gathered preventing us from pursuing the attackers or searching the area for and casualties.

All in all, it seems that the city is becoming more volatile. Like I said before, the evil here lies just beneath the surface and the screams of rebellion are just barely drowned out by the megaphone-amplified chants broadcast from atop the Mosk next door. It will be interesting to see how this change from Saddam to freedom actually comes about. For us, we just confiscate as many weapons as we can from a seemingly endless supply and we'll try to maintain the peace as best we can.

The rest has all been said before. I look forward to relaying you these stories in person when it does not involve endless typing to capture the smallest situation. I will do my best to remember to elaborate mosks and the interesting contrasts in civilization in this city. The brand new BMW M series sharing the relatively modern highway with the horse-drawn carriage and the 1970 orange and white taxi that is so beat up that you cannot make out the manufacturer or model. I will try to remember as best I can. I love you and Mason very much...

Love,

Christian